

PL — Polymers and Life

OCR B (Salters) H433 storyline **PL**. Polymers, proteins and DNA: condensation polymers, amines and amides, amino acid and protein chemistry, optical isomerism, enzyme catalysis and structural analysis.

1. Amines and Amino Acids

Amines

Amine: An organic compound derived from ammonia (NH_3) by replacing one or more hydrogen atoms with alkyl or aryl groups. Primary amines have the formula RNH_2 , secondary amines R_2NH , and tertiary amines R_3N .

Preparation of amines:

- Reaction of a halogenoalkane with excess ammonia in a sealed tube at elevated temperature: $\text{RBr} + 2\text{NH}_3 \rightarrow \text{RNH}_2 + \text{NH}_4\text{Br}$. Excess ammonia is used to minimise further substitution.
- Reduction of a nitrile with LiAlH_4 in dry ether or by catalytic hydrogenation: $\text{RCN} + 4[\text{H}] \rightarrow \text{RCH}_2\text{NH}_2$.
- Reduction of a nitro compound (important for aromatic amines): $\text{C}_6\text{H}_5\text{NO}_2 + 6[\text{H}] \rightarrow (\text{Sn/conc. HCl, reflux}) \text{C}_6\text{H}_5\text{NH}_2 + 2\text{H}_2\text{O}$.

Base properties of amines: Amines act as Brønsted-Lowry bases because the lone pair on nitrogen can accept a proton: $\text{RNH}_2 + \text{H}^+ \rightarrow \text{RNH}_3^+$. Aliphatic amines are stronger bases than ammonia because the electron-donating alkyl groups increase electron density on the nitrogen, making the lone pair more available for protonation. Aromatic amines (e.g. phenylamine, $\text{C}_6\text{H}_5\text{NH}_2$) are weaker bases than ammonia because the nitrogen lone pair is delocalised into the benzene ring, reducing its availability.

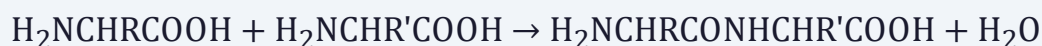
Amino Acids

Amino acid: An organic molecule containing both an amine group ($-\text{NH}_2$) and a carboxylic acid group ($-\text{COOH}$). The α -amino acids found in proteins have both groups attached to the same carbon atom (the α -carbon), along with a hydrogen atom and a variable side chain (R group).

Zwitterions: In solution at the isoelectric point, amino acids exist predominantly as zwitterions — the amine group is protonated ($-\text{NH}_3^+$) and the carboxylic acid group is deprotonated ($-\text{COO}^-$). This gives the molecule both a positive and a negative charge but an overall neutral charge. Zwitterions have high melting points and are soluble in water due to their ionic character.

In acidic solution, the COO^- group is protonated, giving a positive ion. In basic solution, the NH_3^+ group is deprotonated, giving a negative ion.

Peptide Bonds and Proteins



A peptide bond ($-\text{CONH}-$) forms by a condensation reaction between the $-\text{COOH}$ of one amino acid and the $-\text{NH}_2$ of another, releasing water. Proteins are polypeptides formed from many amino acids linked by peptide bonds. Peptide bonds can be broken by hydrolysis (acid or base conditions, or enzymatically).

2. Optical Isomerism

Look again at the general structure of an α -amino acid. The α -carbon carries four groups: $-\text{NH}_2$, $-\text{COOH}$, $-\text{H}$ and the side chain R. For every amino acid except glycine those four groups are all different, and that single fact gives rise to a second kind of stereoisomerism — one that governs how proteins fold, how enzymes select their substrates, and why a drug can be a cure in one form and a poison in the other.

Chiral centre: A carbon atom bonded to four *different* atoms or groups. A molecule containing one is described as **chiral**.

Enantiomers (optical isomers): The two forms of a chiral molecule, which are non-superimposable mirror images of one another.

"Non-superimposable" is the key phrase and it is worth getting a feel for physically. Your two hands are mirror images, but no matter how you rotate them you cannot lay one on the other so that thumb covers thumb and palm covers palm. A chiral molecule is the same: the mirror image is a genuinely different molecule, not the same molecule viewed from another angle.

Finding the Chiral Centre

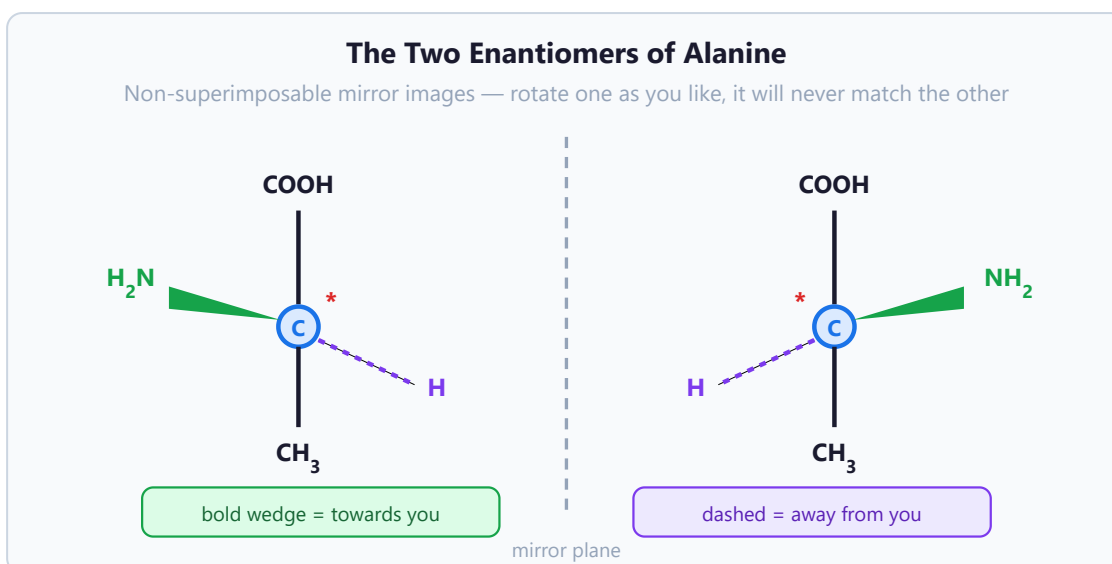
To test a carbon atom, list the four things attached to it and ask whether any two are identical. If all four differ, that carbon is a chiral centre and is usually marked with an asterisk.

Molecule	Groups on the carbon in question	Chiral?
Glycine, $\text{H}_2\text{NCH}_2\text{COOH}$	$-\text{NH}_2$, $-\text{COOH}$, $-\text{H}$, $-\text{H}$	No — two hydrogens are the same
Alanine, $\text{CH}_3\text{CH}(\text{NH}_2)\text{COOH}$	$-\text{NH}_2$, $-\text{COOH}$, $-\text{H}$, $-\text{CH}_3$	Yes
Butan-2-ol, $\text{CH}_3\text{CH}(\text{OH})\text{C}_2\text{H}_5$	$-\text{OH}$, $-\text{H}$, $-\text{CH}_3$, $-\text{C}_2\text{H}_5$	Yes
Propan-2-ol, $\text{CH}_3\text{CH}(\text{OH})\text{CH}_3$	$-\text{OH}$, $-\text{H}$, $-\text{CH}_3$, $-\text{CH}_3$	No — two methyl groups are the same
2-hydroxypropanoic acid (lactic acid)	$-\text{OH}$, $-\text{H}$, $-\text{CH}_3$, $-\text{COOH}$	Yes

Glycine is therefore the only one of the twenty amino acids coded for in proteins that is *not* chiral. All the others exist as a pair of enantiomers, and in living organisms essentially only one of each pair — the L-form — is used to build proteins.

Drawing Optical Isomers

The marks in this question are for showing three dimensions properly, so use the wedge-and-dash convention: two ordinary lines in the plane of the paper, one bold wedge coming towards you, one dashed line going away. Draw the first isomer, then draw a vertical mirror line and reflect every group across it.



Why the Two Forms Are Not the Same

A pair of enantiomers have identical melting point, boiling point, density, solubility and ordinary chemical reactivity, because every bond in one is the same as the corresponding bond in the other. They differ in only two respects, and both follow from their handedness:

- They rotate the plane of **plane-polarised light** by equal amounts in opposite directions — one clockwise, one anticlockwise. This is what "optical" isomerism is named after, and it is how the two forms are told apart in the laboratory, using a polarimeter.
- They behave differently towards *other* chiral molecules. Enzymes, receptors and antibodies are built from L-amino acids and are themselves chiral, so a chiral active site fits one enantiomer of a substrate or drug and not the other — exactly the lock-and-key idea that section 5 returns to.

Racemic mixture (racemate): An equal mixture of the two enantiomers. It shows no rotation of plane-polarised light, because the two opposite rotations cancel exactly. Ordinary laboratory synthesis from achiral starting materials always gives a racemate, since the reagent is equally likely to attack either face of a planar intermediate.

Why This Matters for Medicines

Because a receptor site can distinguish enantiomers, the two forms of a chiral drug can have quite different effects. Only one enantiomer of thalidomide acts as the intended sedative; the other is a teratogen, and the two interconvert in the body, so even administering the pure "safe" form would not have prevented harm. In the case of ibuprofen only the S-enantiomer is the active anti-inflammatory, but the body

converts much of the inactive R-form into it, so the racemate can still be sold. Producing a single enantiomer is expensive — it needs a chiral starting material, a chiral catalyst, an enzyme, or separation of the racemate — but it halves the dose needed and removes whatever the unwanted enantiomer would have done.

Exam Tip: Three marks are regularly lost here. First, when asked to identify chiral centres in a large molecule, check every carbon systematically rather than guessing — and remember a carbon in a C=C or a benzene ring can never be chiral, because it has only three groups attached. Second, when asked to draw the isomers, you must use wedges and dashes; two flat structures drawn side by side score nothing. Third, if asked how the isomers differ, "they rotate plane-polarised light in opposite directions" is the physical difference — do not say they have different melting points or different chemical reactions with ordinary achiral reagents, because they do not.

3. Polymers

Addition Polymers

Formed from alkene monomers by breaking C=C double bonds. No by-product is formed. Examples: poly(ethene), poly(propene), PVC, PTFE. They are non-biodegradable and chemically inert (strong C–C backbone).

Condensation Polymers

Condensation polymerisation: Monomers join together with the loss of a small molecule (usually water) at each linkage. The monomers must have two functional groups each (they are bifunctional).

Polyesters: Formed from a diol (HO–R–OH) and a dicarboxylic acid (HOOC–R'–COOH), or from a hydroxycarboxylic acid (HO–R–COOH). The linkage is an ester bond (–COO–). Example: Terylene (PET) from ethane-1,2-diol and benzene-1,4-dicarboxylic acid.

Polyamides: Formed from a diamine (H₂N–R–NH₂) and a dicarboxylic acid (HOOC–R'–COOH), or from an amino acid. The linkage is a peptide/amide bond (–CONH–). Examples: nylon-6,6 from 1,6-diaminohexane and hexanedioic acid; Kevlar from 1,4-diaminobenzene and benzene-1,4-dicarboxylic acid.

Biodegradability: Condensation polymers are generally biodegradable because the ester or amide bonds can be hydrolysed by water, acids, bases, or enzymes. Addition polymers are generally non-biodegradable. Biodegradable polymers reduce landfill waste but may produce greenhouse gases (CO_2 , CH_4) during decomposition.

Exam Tip: When drawing condensation polymer repeat units, remember to show the linkage (ester or amide bond) and indicate where water was lost. The repeat unit should be enclosed in brackets with continuation bonds on each side. Be able to identify the monomers from a given polymer structure by breaking the ester or amide bonds and adding back H and OH.

4. DNA and RNA

Proteins are condensation polymers of amino acids. DNA and RNA are condensation polymers too, built from a different monomer: the nucleotide.

Nucleotide: A monomer with three components joined together — a **phosphate** group, a **sugar** (deoxyribose in DNA, ribose in RNA) and a nitrogen-containing **base**. The structures of all three are given on the H433 Data Sheet, so you do not need to memorise them; you do need to be able to identify which part is which and where the condensation reactions occur.

Building the Polymer

Two different condensation reactions hold a nucleic acid together, and water is lost in each:

- **Base to sugar:** an -NH group of the base condenses with an -OH group on carbon 1 of the sugar, so each sugar carries a base.
- **Phosphate to sugar:** an -OH of the phosphate group condenses with an -OH on the sugar, forming a phosphate ester link. Repeating this joins sugar–phosphate–sugar–phosphate into the **sugar–phosphate backbone**, with the bases sticking out sideways.

Because the links are made by condensation, they can be broken by **hydrolysis** — the same relationship as for polyesters and polyamides earlier in this storyline.

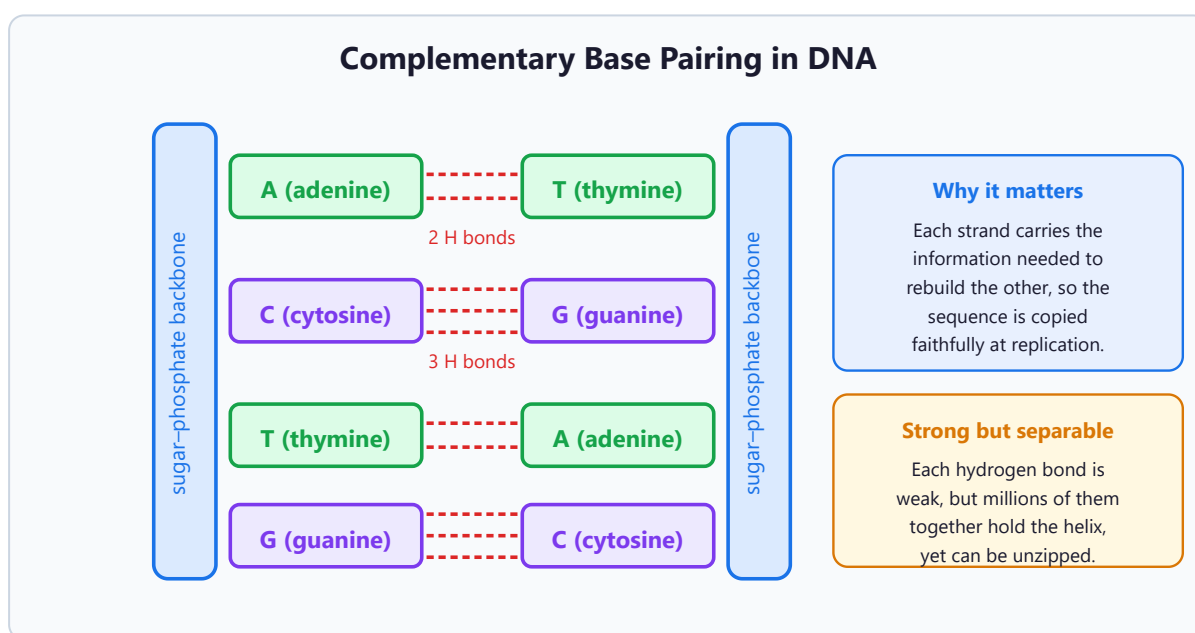
The Bases and Base Pairing

Polymer	Sugar	Bases	Structure
DNA	Deoxyribose	Adenine (A), Thymine (T), Cytosine (C), Guanine (G)	Two strands wound into a double helix
RNA	Ribose	Adenine (A), Uracil (U) , Cytosine (C), Guanine (G)	Normally a single strand

The two DNA strands are held together by **hydrogen bonds** between the bases, and the pairing is strictly complementary:

A ... T (two hydrogen bonds) C ... G (three hydrogen bonds)

A pairs with T (or with U in RNA) and C pairs with G because those are the only combinations in which an N–H or O–H hydrogen-bond donor on one base lines up with a lone pair on N or O on the other, at the right distance and orientation, for every hydrogen bond in the pair. A purine always pairs with a pyrimidine, which keeps the two strands a constant distance apart all the way along.



Why Hydrogen Bonding is the Right Strength

An individual hydrogen bond is weak compared with a covalent bond, but there are one for every base pair along the whole molecule, so collectively they hold the double helix firmly. That combination is exactly what replication needs: the two strands can be unzipped by an enzyme without breaking any covalent

bond, and each separated strand then acts as a template on which the complementary bases assemble in only one possible order. The sequence is therefore copied faithfully.

From DNA to Protein

The base sequence of DNA is a code. Read in groups of three — a **triplet** or **codon** — it specifies the order in which amino acids are joined:

1. A section of DNA is used as the template to build a strand of messenger RNA, with U appearing wherever the DNA had A.
2. The mRNA is read three bases at a time, and each codon specifies one amino acid. The Data Sheet gives a short list of codons, for example GGU for glycine, GCC for alanine and GUC for valine.
3. The amino acids are joined in that order by peptide links, giving a protein with a defined primary structure.

Because the primary structure determines how the chain folds, the base sequence ultimately determines the protein's three-dimensional shape and therefore what it does.

Worked Example — Using the Genetic Code:

A section of an mRNA strand reads GGU GCC GUC. Using the Data Sheet codons (glycine GGU, alanine GCC, valine GUC), give the amino acid sequence and the DNA template from which it was transcribed.

Amino acid sequence: **glycine – alanine – valine**

The DNA template is complementary to the mRNA, with T replacing U and each base paired A–U/T and C–G:

mRNA	G	G	U	G	C	C	G	U	C
DNA	C	C	A	C	G	G	C	A	G

The **Human Genome Project** set out to read the entire base sequence of human DNA. A working draft was announced in 2001, the finished sequence followed in 2003, and the last remaining gaps — in highly repetitive regions that the original methods could not resolve — were closed by the Telomere-to-Telomere consortium, which published a gapless sequence in 2022 and completed the Y chromosome in 2023. The sequence underpins work on inherited disease and on medicines matched to a patient's own genetics.

Exam Tip: Two marks are routinely dropped here. First, DNA and RNA are *condensation* polymers — say that water is lost at each link. Second, when asked why base pairing is specific, do not just say "A pairs with T": explain that the hydrogen-bond donors and acceptors on the two bases match up in size, position and orientation, and give the 2 and 3 hydrogen bonds for A–T and C–G.

5. Enzyme Catalysis and Molecular Recognition

Enzyme: A protein that acts as a catalyst for a biological reaction. The substrate binds to a small region called the **active site**, whose shape and chemistry are created by the way the protein chain folds — that is, the active site is part of the tertiary structure.

Enzymes are extraordinarily effective catalysts, speeding reactions by factors of millions while working at body temperature and near-neutral pH. They achieve this the same way any catalyst does: by providing an alternative route of lower activation enthalpy.

The Characteristics of Enzyme Catalysis

Characteristic	Observation	Explanation in terms of the active site
Specificity	An enzyme catalyses one reaction, or one narrow class of reaction, and ignores other molecules	Only a substrate with the right size, shape, charge distribution and hydrogen-bonding groups fits into the active site and binds
Temperature sensitivity	Rate rises with temperature to an optimum, then falls sharply — unlike an ordinary catalysed reaction	Above the optimum, the intermolecular bonds holding the tertiary structure (hydrogen bonds, ionic bonds, sulfur–sulfur bridges, instantaneous dipole–induced dipole bonds) are broken. The chain unfolds, the active site loses its shape, and the enzyme is denatured
pH sensitivity	Rate peaks at an optimum pH and falls either side	Changing pH protonates or deprotonates $-\text{NH}_2$ and $-\text{COOH}$ side chains, destroying the ionic bonds that hold the tertiary structure and altering the charges inside the active site

Competitive inhibition	A similar-shaped molecule slows the reaction, but the effect can be overcome by adding more substrate	The inhibitor is close enough in shape to occupy the active site, blocking the substrate. Substrate and inhibitor compete for the same sites, so raising the substrate concentration restores the rate
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The Rate Curve

Plotting rate against substrate concentration for an enzyme-catalysed reaction gives a curve with a distinctive shape: it rises steeply at first, then levels off to a horizontal plateau.

Region	Order with respect to substrate	Why
Low [substrate]	First order — rate is proportional to [substrate]	Most active sites are empty, so doubling the substrate concentration doubles the number of successful encounters
High [substrate]	Zero order — rate is independent of [substrate]	Every active site is already occupied, so the enzyme is saturated. Adding more substrate cannot speed things up; the rate now depends only on how fast the enzyme can turn substrate into product

The levelling-off is strong evidence for the active-site model itself: a simple collision between two free molecules would not saturate.

Molecular Recognition and Medicines

The same idea — a molecule being recognised by a binding site because it fits in three dimensions — explains how most medicines work.

Pharmacophore: The part of a drug molecule responsible for its biological activity, the group of atoms that actually interacts with the receptor site. Other groups on the molecule **modify** it — altering how strongly it binds, how soluble it is, how long it survives in the body, or how selective it is.

Binding to a receptor site depends on three-dimensional fit, and the interactions involved are the familiar ones: hydrogen bonds, ionic bonds between charged groups, instantaneous dipole–induced dipole bonds,

and sometimes covalent bond formation. For binding to happen the molecule must match the site in **size**, in **shape**, in the **orientation** of its functional groups, and in its ability to **form bonds** at the right points. This is why two optical isomers of the same drug, identical in every other respect, can differ completely in activity: only one of them fits.

Many medicines are deliberately designed as **enzyme inhibitors**. A molecule shaped like the natural substrate occupies the active site, the enzyme cannot do its job, and a biochemical pathway is shut down. Methanol poisoning is treated on the same principle in reverse: methanol is only dangerous because an enzyme oxidises it to methanoic acid, so the patient is given ethanol, which competes for the same active site and is oxidised instead, allowing the methanol to be excreted unchanged.

Exam Tip: Denaturing is not the same as inhibiting. Denaturing destroys the tertiary structure by breaking intermolecular bonds, and is usually irreversible; competitive inhibition leaves the enzyme intact and can be reversed by adding more substrate. If a question tells you the effect is overcome by increasing substrate concentration, that is your signal for competitive inhibition — say so explicitly.